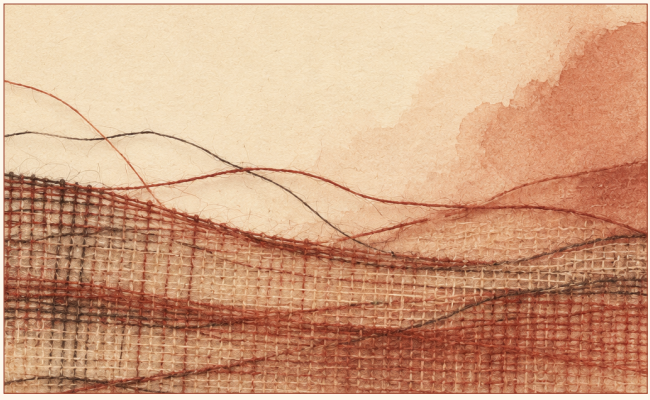
Mirgan Households and Kotpad Textiles

People, Colour and Livelihoods in Odisha



Ahimanikya Satapathy

FIRST EDITION

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Prepared from published sources. No field visit, household survey or new interview was conducted for this edition.

Named testimony and historical material are attributed in the chapters and references. No endorsement by the named practitioners or institutions is implied.

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Introduction

A piece of cloth makes many kinds of work visible at once. Its colour holds the decisions of a dyer. Its structure records work at a loom. Its journey to a wearer depends on people who arrange materials, place orders, carry goods and settle payments. Yet the label attached to the finished textile may name only a place, a technique or a seller. This book follows the relationships that lie behind that label.

Kotpad provides the geographical centre of the account. Mirgan households provide its human focus. Neither term supplies a ready-made boundary. A place associated with textile expertise can serve households elsewhere; a community name in an old record cannot settle the identities of everyone working today. The opening chapters therefore begin with names, localities and historical traces before turning to colour, livelihoods and change.

The chapters connect textile history with the practical questions of a working life: preparing yarn, judging colour, arranging an order and receiving payment. Together these activities help explain how a household can keep producing and how a learner can find opportunities to practise.

Hasita Panika's attention to root material brings practical judgement into the story of colour. Jema Panika's concern about recognition directs attention towards work that can disappear behind admiration for a finished sari. Hari Tanti's reported transaction distinguishes thread costs from money assigned to shared work, while Jagabandhu Panika's account shows why payment timing matters. These published accounts, examined in the chapters that follow, retain the names and circumstances of the people who give them.

The continuity of textile knowledge depends on opportunities to exercise it. Knowing a technique does not secure materials or orders, and an order becomes available income only when

payment arrives. Recognition matters too, but it cannot tell us how money or decisions are shared. These connections place the craft within the conditions of everyday work.

The first part locates people and traces the past through written records and surviving objects. The second follows the work: a transaction, the making of colour, the contributors to a textile and the routes through which it travels. The third considers water, roots, fuel and the working year, then examines what support programmes document and how learning relates to the future. The order moves from where and who to how work becomes possible.

This first edition brings together published reporting, named testimony, process documentation, museum catalogues and institutional records. It was prepared without a field visit. The method and source notes explain how the account distinguishes other people's observations from interpretation and where the evidence remains incomplete.

Above all, this book treats practitioners as people with working lives and aspirations. Continuing a craft may involve adapting it, combining it with other work, teaching selected skills or choosing a different occupation. Admiration for textile knowledge should make those lives more intelligible. It should leave the people who hold that knowledge room to decide what they wish to carry forward.

A note on method and this edition

This edition is a desk-based synthesis prepared in November 2026. No field visit, household survey or new interview was conducted for it. Named testimony and descriptions of work come from the credited published sources. The separate research archive includes a proposed household survey; it does not record a completed survey.

The evidence falls into several groups: named-maker and journalistic accounts; craft-process documentation; historical writing and museum catalogues; administrative records; and implementer or government reports. Each serves a different purpose. A catalogue attribution is not a workshop provenance. A village population is not a count of active weavers. A training target, recorded attendance and sustained paid practice measure different things.

Publication, observation and event dates are kept separate. An undated maker page cannot securely convert a remembered age into a calendar year. A film's production year does not automatically date its webpage. A later update to an article does not prove a new visit to a plantation or household. Historical place names and community classifications remain attributed to their sources.

References are numbered once across the book. Repeated citations to one source retain the same number. Sources concerning the same person or project are not treated as independent confirmations merely because they appear on different websites. In particular, the two Jagabandhu accounts share a subject, and the World Bank documents belong to one project reporting chain.

Some passages were available only as indexed text or earlier inspected catalogue records. The source notes identify these limits. Missing costs, sample sizes, dates and household identities have not been supplied by inference. Unreconciled programme figures and the excluded proceedings citation are discussed in the source notes.

PART ONE · PEOPLE AND HISTORY

CHAPTER 1

Mirgan households and the geography of Kotpad cloth

Where does a textile belong? The answer may begin with the place whose name it carries, but making and selling it can connect several places. A household may obtain yarn from one locality, weave in another and sell to buyers across a district or state boundary. To understand Kotpad cloth, we need to follow those relationships as well as locate the town.

A March 2025 Sambad report describes weavers in Mundaguda in Nabarangpur district obtaining aal-dyed yarn from Kotpad and selling cloth in Chhattisgarh. The report, available here through indexed Odia text, identifies a connection between a source of dyed yarn, a weaving locality and a market. Its importance is geographical: the work associated with Kotpad is not necessarily contained within the town. It does not establish the quantity or regularity of that exchange. [1]

A town and the relationships around it

The name Kotpad gives this textile tradition a recognisable centre. Yet the centre and the extent of production are different things. An account organised entirely around the town could overlook households that participate through yarn purchases, commissioned work or sales without living inside its boundary.

Jagabandhu Panika offers a named example. Boito's undated maker page identifies him with Batasana and places his home about ten kilometres from Kotpad. In the account, he describes making saris and odhanis and selling to local shopkeepers. The testimony connects a maker, a locality and a selling relationship; it

does not supply an administrative boundary for the entire craft. [2]

A postal address, revenue village, gram panchayat and weaving neighbourhood may refer to overlapping places. A gram panchayat is a unit of local government; a neighbourhood describes where people live and work. Neither alone defines the area served by a textile trade.

Names carry different histories

W. Francis's 1907 gazetteer places the name Mirigáni around Kotpad. Chapter 2 examines this historical reference; it does not define how every household identifies today. [3]

Contemporary accounts use names including Panika and Tanti when describing makers. Annapurna Devi Pandey uses them in an account of master weavers commissioning cloth from other households. That specific relationship does not define everyone involved in Kotpad textiles. [4]

"Mirgan households" therefore identifies the focus of this study without defining a closed population in advance. Participation in a textile economy and membership of a community are related questions, but one cannot be established solely from the other. A surname, an occupation or inclusion in a programme list is insufficient to settle identity.

Locating Batasana

The settlement records provide useful anchors. The Census 2011 catalogue records Batasona under Kotpad block, with village code 428106. Older administrative lists use related spellings, including Botasona and Batasana, at the gram-panchayat level. Together with the maker account, these records give a strong candidate for locating the craft locality called Batasana. They do not independently identify Jagabandhu's household or prove that all the names describe precisely the same boundary. [5]; [6]

Bansuli and Dungriguda

A second example shows why spelling alone cannot settle geography. Census records identify Bansuli with code 428148, while Basuli appears separately as code 428094. Those similar names should remain separate unless evidence establishes a relationship. [5]

An indexed Ministry of Textiles training-centre record associates Bansuli and Dungriguda in an address using Kotpad as the postal location. This remains an address-level lead, not confirmation of a hamlet or administrative boundary. [7]

Which Mundaguda

The regional yarn account introduces another problem: the same settlement name can occur in more than one district. A Nabarangpur district table lists Mundaguda under Modeigam gram panchayat in Kosagumuda block. This provides an administrative candidate for the weaving locality described in the Sambad report. An older government village list also records a Mundaguda under Bhansuli gram panchayat in Kotpad block, Koraput. These entries must not be merged simply because the village names match. [8]; [9]

The district table counts a village population for its own administrative purpose. It does not count weaving families. Its totals therefore cannot be compared directly with a craft report as if both measured participation in the same activity.

Counting people and following cloth

A textile economy contains several possible populations: people who dye, people who weave, households owning looms, sellers, trainees and households practising intermittently. These categories can overlap. A training register may identify participation in a course while saying little about continued work. A village population total includes people with other occupations. Neither is automatically a count of active weaving households.

Kotpad emerges as a centre within a wider network of textile work. Locating households is one part of its geography; following yarn, cloth and orders is another. The historical record adds a further dimension, showing how names and objects have been attached to places over time.

CHAPTER 2

Historical traces in records and cloth

A museum label can preserve a textile while leaving its maker unnamed. In the Museum of Art & Photography's catalogue, a cotton dhoti associated with Koraput carries the identifier TXT.02336, a broad twentieth-century date and an unknown maker. Another entry, a textile fragment numbered TXT.02607, carries a date range of 1984-2016. These records give surviving cloth a place within a collection. Their broad dates also reveal how much of an object's earlier life can remain outside its catalogue description. [10]; [11]

The history of Kotpad textiles has to bring such objects into conversation with written accounts of people, materials and work. Each preserves something different. A gazetteer locates a community name. A dyeing account records a process and its suppliers. A catalogue identifies a cloth within a collection. Together they provide historical depth, although they do not form a continuous biography of every household or an exact account of the craft's beginnings.

A community name in a dated record

W. Francis's *Madras District Gazetteers: Vizagapatam*, published in 1907, places the names Mirigáni and Kobbiriya around Kotpad in its chapter on people. The reference matters because it connects names and locality at a documented point in time. It can anchor a historical discussion without being treated as the date when the people arrived or their textile practice began. [3]

A colonial gazetteer also preserves the categories and interests of its compiler. Its descriptions should remain attributed rather than become the book's own unqualified definitions of living

communities. Present-day identity cannot be read straight from an administrative description written more than a century earlier.

The short Mirigani entry in Edgar Thurston's 1909 volume provides another historical classification. It is not a description of Kotpad dyeing. Placing it beside Francis may help trace the written use of a name, but the two references cannot supply an early recipe, a dated loom or a household genealogy that neither contains. [12]

Knowledge recorded through other people

Uzramma's *A future vision for natural dyeing in India* brings a different kind of evidence into view. Its Kotpad passage describes bark from secondary roots moving through forest harvesters and local traders to dyers. It attributes the account of women's dyeing knowledge and the process to Jagada Rajappa's field notes. Here the historical subject is a relationship between materials, suppliers and expertise. [13]

Uzramma's paper and Rajappa's field notes occupy different places in the evidence trail. Retaining the observer's name acknowledges the source of the knowledge and avoids counting a later synthesis as another observation.

Dating the passage requires equal care. The hosted filename labels the paper December 2001, while its bibliography assigns Rajappa's unpublished notes a span of 1986-2000. That span does not identify the year in which the Kotpad observations were made. The account belongs within the historical record, but an exact observation date cannot be extracted from those two labels.

The different dates of a textile

For a cloth, manufacture, purchase, inheritance, exhibition and museum accession are separate events. A date attached to one cannot automatically answer a question about another. An accession identifier gives an object a stable reference within a collection; its numbers require documentation before they can be interpreted as a production year.

The MAP records retain broad dates and regional attributions. “Koraput” does not identify a particular Kotpad workshop, and the fragment’s 1984-2016 range cannot be narrowed by choosing a midpoint. Neither catalogue entry names a maker. [10]; [11]

The absence of a maker’s name in a catalogue is a limit of that record. It should not make the labour anonymous in our interpretation, nor encourage the invention of an artisan biography. The cloth was made by people; recovering their names requires evidence beyond a stylistic resemblance.

Design collections and individual cloths

The Kalingavastra material introduces the history of organised design work and collecting. A searchable older scan of Rta Kapur Chishti’s *Saris of India: Tradition and Beyond* identifies entry 10/42 as a Kotapad development in the Kalingavastra collection. Elsewhere, the chapter dates collection production with Sambalpur Bastralaya to late 1996. The programme account and the individual entry are connected, but the programme date does not independently date every specimen. [14]

Entry 10/42 is a lead concerning one textile. Its maker and commissioning circumstances remain unresolved, and its page reference belongs to the edition examined.

A later study by Sareekah Agarwaal and Ruby Kashyap Sood records Ruchira Ghose’s recollection of participating in the Kalingavastra project and purchasing saris for herself, relatives and friends. This introduces the purchaser’s perspective and the continuing life of textiles in a private collection. It does not identify

a Kotpad maker for a particular piece or establish a match with entry 10/42. [15]

Read together, the catalogue and purchaser account suggest how a textile history might become more complete: a design entry could be connected to a retained cloth, a purchase record and a maker. Until those links are demonstrated, the sources should remain related leads rather than a completed provenance.

Continuity leaves room for change

An inherited technique can continue while products, buyers, tools or working arrangements change. Historical continuity need not mean that every aspect of production has remained fixed. Conversely, the appearance of a familiar material or motif does not by itself establish an uninterrupted line of transmission.

The records examined here give several anchors: a locality named in 1907; an attributed account of dyeing knowledge; catalogued objects with broad dates; and a design collection documented through publication and recollection. Their different perspectives are part of their value. None needs to stand for the entire history.

These traces give Kotpad a documented past while leaving its beginnings open. Each new link between a textile, a maker and a transaction could deepen that history. The next chapter turns to a contemporary transaction in which some of those relationships are visible.

PART TWO · MAKING AND EARNING

CHAPTER 3

What a sari price reveals about Kotpad

A sari sold for INR 5,000 does not tell us that its weaver earned INR 5,000. In Annapurna Devi Pandey's account of a weaving household supplying a master weaver, INR 2,000 of that amount went towards thread. The remaining INR 3,000 was assigned to five days of work by two people. The example, attributed to Hari Tanti and published in October 2023, offers a concrete starting point for understanding Kotpad's textile economy: a price contains several claims on the same money. [4]

Several people within one transaction

Pandey describes Panika master weavers commissioning work from Tanti households. In this arrangement, the household making the cloth and the person placing the commission occupy different positions in the transaction. A sale by one becomes an input into another person's business. The example places cooperation and dependence within the production account, rather than allowing the named seller to stand for everyone involved. [4]

The example does not establish the margin eventually retained by a trader or master weaver. A later selling price would need to be linked to the same cloth, along with the costs and risks of that sale. Comparing one household's receipt with an unrelated retail price would turn two different observations into an invented chain of profit.

Colour belongs in the account of work

The economics of a textile begin before the finished cloth changes hands. Chitrangada Choudhury's 2017 reporting describes women preparing and washing yarn and tending dye baths in Kotpad. Jema Panika's account draws attention to the effort behind colour and the recognition given to that work. These activities belong in any account of production, even when the most visible public figure is the person who weaves or sells the cloth. [16]

Recognition and control of money must also be kept separate. A published description can show that a woman performs skilled work without revealing who buys inputs, receives the sale proceeds or decides how those proceeds are used. Treating the household as one undifferentiated worker conceals these questions; assuming the answers would conceal variation just as effectively.

Why ranges cannot become a wage

Koraput Farmers' Association's (KFA) 2019-20 annual report gives sari receipts of INR 5,000-10,000 and colour and material costs of INR 2,000-3,000. It also describes working days and durations. These figures indicate the kinds of amounts reported in that institutional account, but they are not a set of matched transactions connecting one sari's price, inputs and labour. [17]

It is tempting to select a price from one end of a range, subtract a cost from the other and divide by a reported number of days. The resulting figure would appear precise while lacking a real order behind it. Differences in product, complexity, contributors and input ownership could account for part of the variation.

When money arrives

Price is only one term of a transaction. In a June 2024 interview, Jagabandhu Panika associated prompt payments from Boito with improved financial stability. A separate, undated account hosted by the brand describes some local shops paying him only after resale. The contrast makes settlement timing a concrete issue within one maker's experience. [18]; [2]

Both accounts concern Jagabandhu; one is hosted by his commercial partner. They record his appreciation of dependable payment without measuring an increase in net earnings.

Payment timing can affect what a household is able to do with a receipt. Prompt settlement may help purchase the next inputs or meet an expense that falls due before resale. These are possible benefits of the arrangement Jagabandhu values; their scale has not been measured here.

The useful comparison is therefore between complete terms of trade: what is ordered, who owns the yarn, who provides advances, when cloth is accepted and when the balance is paid. Calling a buyer traditional or modern tells us less than knowing those terms.

What a fair account should retain

The terms of a transaction also change the meaning of support. More visibility or a higher displayed price might help, but neither by itself demonstrates improved returns to those preparing, dyeing and weaving. Equally, a modest price cannot establish a poor outcome without knowing the work, costs and terms attached to it. The relevant unit is the actual relationship and transaction.

Hari Tanti's INR 5,000 sari makes one distinction concrete: thread and shared work are both inside the receipt. Jagabandhu's testimony adds another: the amount and timing of payment have different consequences. Following these transactions brings attention back to the work they support, beginning with the making of colour.

CHAPTER 4

Making colour in Kotpad

In Chitrangada Choudhury's 2017 reporting from Kotpad, Hasita Panika connects the dryness of aal root material with how finely it can be ground and the strength of the resulting colour. This small observation puts a dyer's judgement at the beginning of the process. Colour depends on recognising and preparing a material, well before a finished sari reaches a buyer. [16]

Knowing the ingredients is only part of the craft. Decisions about readiness, handling and repetition give the process its practical character.

The material before the colour

Uzramma's account, drawing on Jagada Rajappa's field notes, describes secondary-root bark passing through forest harvesters and local traders to dyers. The person preparing the colour is not necessarily the person who collected the root. The observation date remains unresolved. [13]

Root, root bark and powder are different forms of material. Their condition matters when comparing purchases: the same weight of fresh root and dried powder does not describe the same usable input.

The botanical name also requires care. Several published accounts identify aal as *Morinda citrifolia*, while Uzramma uses *Morinda tinctoria*. These are source identifications, not verification of the actual tree supplying a particular household. This book therefore uses aal for the craft material and retains botanical names only with their attribution. A specimen-linked identification would be needed to settle the identity of a specific supply plant.

Preparing the cotton

Sudha Dhingra's Sahapedia account describes cotton-yarn preparation with castor oil, cow-dung paste and ash water. Feet as well as hands work the hanks. In her account, ash settles in water and the clearer liquid is used; repeated treatment and drying precede dyeing. She records foaming during treatment as a sign of readiness. [19]

Preparation calls for more than applying ingredients. In Dhingra's description, the dyer also judges when the treated yarn is ready for the next stage.

Dastkari Haat Samiti's documentation, with images labelled 2017, records sorting, oil treatment, dung application, ash-water washing and drying. Its sequence also includes early starching, a detail retained separately from Dhingra's account. Text is credited to Jaya Jaitly, photographs to Chirodeep Chaudhuri, and the documented work to Gobardhan Panika and the community. [20]

Developing a shade

In Dhingra's account, prepared yarn enters an aal-powder bath in an earthen vessel. Heating, exposure to sunlight and repeated dyeing help develop the desired shade. She describes further treatment for deeper colour, including iron filings in a later bath for a dark coffee shade. The account gives a roughly 4.5-5 kg yarn lot, 12-15 days of preparation and about 25-30 elapsed days overall. These figures describe her account, not a production standard. [19]

Elapsed time includes waiting and drying as well as hands-on work. Dhingra's month-long process therefore measures neither continuous labour nor continuous heating, although waiting can still affect when an order is ready.

Diana Sahu's April 2020 report supplies a household-specific example of shade-making. It describes Jemma adding iron dust to aal preparations to obtain a chosen maroon, while Gobardhan Panika discusses a palette including maroon, black, brown and

unbleached off-white. This is a report of the couple's work, not a universal colour chart. [21]

Dastkari's documentation separately identifies ground iron sulphate with black yarn and names myrobalan among the materials. Iron dust, filings and purchased sulphate should not be treated as interchangeable labels. Nor should maroon, dark coffee and black be collapsed into one outcome. The accounts describe variations that deserve to remain visible. [20]

Washing and the passage towards weaving

Choudhury records women washing yarn at a pond and checking yarn hanging on bamboo frames as it moves between stages. Her reporting also brings Jema Panika's concern about recognition into the account: the finished colours may be admired without the dyers' effort being understood. [16]

Washing extends the workplace beyond the dye vessel. Yarn has to be carried, handled and dried at suitable places. Chapter 7 examines the access to water and space on which these stages depend.

The Metropolitan Museum of Art's Spring 2019 conservation newsletter records cotton-yarn preparation, foot-kneading in dung paste, drying and dyeing, alongside Gobardhan Panica weaving on a pit loom. Its captions connect several kinds of work within a textile account. The newsletter date is a publication date, not proof that every recorded activity occurred that year. [22]

Recognising what the dyer knows

The documented work involves successive judgements about material condition, yarn readiness and shade. A description of ingredients captures only part of that knowledge.

Preparation, handling and adjustment shape the colour that a wearer eventually sees. Their importance can disappear from a product label that names only a weave or a seller.

The material's natural origin does not, by itself, establish environmental performance, safe handling or colour durability. The process accounts describe practice; they are not laboratory tests of those properties.

Making colour in Kotpad is therefore part of the textile's skilled authorship. The work deserves to be described with enough precision to distinguish stages and variations, and enough attribution to keep its practitioners in view. Before colour becomes a feature admired in cloth, it is a result that someone has worked to achieve.

CHAPTER 5

The people behind a finished textile

A finished textile brings several kinds of work into one object. Colour, structure and design are visible together, although the people responsible for them may have worked at different stages or in different households. Naming the weaver is important. Understanding the making of the cloth also requires attention to the dyer, the person arranging an order and those through whom skills are learned.

In her 2017 reporting from Kotpad, Chitrangada Choudhury records Jema Panika's concern that wearers may not understand the effort involved in creating the colours they admire. The question reaches beyond praise for a beautiful sari. It asks whether appreciation follows the work far enough to recognise its contributors. [16]

Working towards the same cloth

Diana Sahu's April 2020 account describes Gobardhan Panika developing motifs while Jemma prepares colour for their textile work. The report presents their activity as a collaboration, connecting the creation of shades with the development of designs. The source uses the spelling Jemma; Choudhury uses Jema. Keeping the attribution visible avoids treating differences in published spelling as evidence of different people. [21]

Sahu's account places two practitioners within the making of the textile. It does not allocate every decision or reveal how the couple share expenses and proceeds.

Judgements about colour shape a textile's appearance alongside decisions made at the loom. The work described as preparation therefore belongs within its authorship.

A household is not the whole production network

The relationship between dyeing and weaving need not be contained within a single home. Sudha Dhingra describes women dyeing yarn for their own families' weaving and selling dyed yarn to other weavers, including beyond Kotpad. In this account, a dyer can contribute to textiles made elsewhere through the sale of a prepared material. [19]

That relationship complicates the idea of a self-contained artisan household producing a cloth from beginning to end. Depending on the transaction, the dyer's product may be yarn rather than a finished sari. Recognising the dyer only as a helper to a household weaver would miss that possibility.

Annapurna Devi Pandey's account of Panika master weavers commissioning cloth from Tanti households adds another connection. A person associated publicly with an order or a business need not be the person who performs all its weaving. The account identifies commissioning as part of the work linking households and markets. [4]

Recognition and remuneration

Being named, being paid and having authority over a decision are different forms of participation. A photograph credit may identify a practitioner without showing how payment is arranged. A household receipt may combine several people's contributions. A seller's public visibility may tell us little about who determined the shade or solved a production problem.

Choudhury's reporting foregrounds women's dyeing expertise and the limited recognition it receives. It supports taking recognition seriously in its own right. It does not provide an account of how every household distributes money or decides on expenditure. [16]

Learning continues after the beginning

Jagabandhu Panika's account on Boito's maker page describes learning by watching and sitting with his father. He distinguishes earlier work with lines and borders from the more complex motifs he developed later. The account presents skill as something extended through practice, not acquired in a single moment. Because the page is undated, its statements about age and elapsed years should not be converted into precise calendar dates. [2]

Jagabandhu's progression suggests that teaching can continue within paid practice. A learner may contribute simpler work while developing the ability to handle more complex designs.

The account also gives teaching a place in a textile's history. Someone who demonstrates a technique or helps a learner solve a problem contributes to a skill that can outlast the lesson, even if they did not work on the finished cloth.

Roles that can change

Published descriptions often associate women with dyeing and men with weaving. These accounts document particular arrangements, but other records make an exclusive rule inappropriate. An Asian Heritage Foundation (AHF) project restructuring paper reports women beneficiaries in Kotpad taking up weaving. The passage supplies neither a local count nor evidence that no woman there had woven previously. It is a report of participation in that intervention. [23]

A later institutional record also deserves precise reading. The Central University of Odisha's release of 19 October 2025 reports 21 master weavers, including five women, attending management training with the Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Sambalpur at Sunabeda on 18-19 October. The programme concerned business management, branding and digital opportunities. It was not presented as initial loom training. [24]

Changing a role can raise several questions at once. Taking up weaving may add a skill, alter the allocation of time or create

another route to earnings. Whether it reduces, replaces or adds to existing work cannot be assumed. The question is what the change means in the participant's working life.

Seeing the contributors clearly

The people behind a textile are connected through production, exchange and learning. Some contributions are embodied in its colour and structure; others help bring an order into being or pass a skill to another person. These relationships are more informative than a single portrait of an isolated artisan.

The finished textile remains a shared point of reference. Following the contributions that made it possible gives its beauty a human history: particular people making decisions, learning from others and working through relationships. Recognition begins with describing those contributions accurately.

CHAPTER 6

Where Kotpad cloth travels

Cloth can travel as a purchase, a gift, an inheritance or a garment made for a new audience. Those journeys give it different kinds of value. A textile retained for an occasion may remain important long after its original sale; a design displayed at an exhibition may attract attention before any order is placed. Understanding where Kotpad cloth travels means keeping these uses and transactions in view together.

The available accounts describe regional exchange alongside newer design markets. They do not establish that one has replaced the other. Nor do they allow a reliable division of sales between local buyers, urban customers and other channels. What they provide is a set of relationships through which cloth acquires purpose, reaches buyers and becomes visible.

Cloth ordered for an occasion

Sudha Dhingra's account of Panika weaving in Bastar and neighbouring Koraput describes *Mai luga* as cloth commissioned within a budget for a wedding gift from the groom to the bride's mother. It also explains how names associated with borders and layouts help identify designs when orders are taken. These are regional descriptions, not rules to assign to every Kotpad household. [25]

This account puts the intended use close to the beginning of production. The buyer is not simply choosing a finished object from a display. An occasion, a budget and a recognisable design help define what is wanted. The relationship between wearer, purchaser and maker is therefore part of the textile's meaning as well as its commercial history.

Dhingra also describes inherited aal cloth retained for special occasions. Retaining, wearing and buying cloth are different

activities: an inherited textile can continue to matter without generating another sale. [25]

Ceremonial use should not be made into a universal interpretation of motifs. A cloth's role in a wedding, the local name of a design and the meaning attributed to an individual figure are separate questions. Each deserves its own account from the people concerned.

Yarn moves before the finished cloth

As Chapter 1 shows, the reported exchange between Kotpad, Mundaguda and Chhattisgarh involves dyed yarn as well as finished cloth. A buyer of prepared yarn participates at a different stage from a wearer purchasing a sari. Following only the finished garment would miss that connection. [1]

New forms and new audiences

In a June 2024 interview, Boito founder Richa Maheshwari describes developing garments beyond saris and stoles, including jackets and trench coats. Her account presents these forms as a way to reach other audiences; it does not measure demand from them. [18]

Boito's own Kotpad page credits Gobardhan and Jema Panika's work as the inspiration for its Kotpad Jacket. That credit is meaningful but specific: inspiration is not an item-by-item record of who dyed, wove or assembled each garment sold under the name. [26]

Tailoring adds decisions about cut, placement, dimensions and finishing. These decisions create further contributions to trace alongside dyeing and weaving. A jacket and the length of cloth from which it is made have connected but distinct production histories.

For the same reason, their displayed prices cannot establish an artisan's share through simple subtraction. An unrelated sari receipt does not supply the material cost of a jacket. The

transaction analysis in Chapter 3 remains relevant: the useful comparison follows a particular product through its actual contributors and payments.

Exhibition is one kind of evidence

India Art Fair's 2025 archive lists Boito supported by Devi Art Foundation. This confirms a documented exhibition channel. It does not identify the number of Kotpad pieces sold there or the payments made to particular households. [27]

A national showcase

A Ministry of Tribal Affairs release dated 7 August 2026 records Kotpad cotton among the textiles displayed at the RISA flagship store in New Delhi during *Tribal Weaves of India*. The event, organised with TRIFED, presented tribal textiles alongside designer collections and other crafts. It places Kotpad cotton within a documented national showcase. [28]

The release describes wider ambitions for market access and livelihoods. It also refers generally to textiles sourced from tribal weavers. It does not identify a Kotpad supplier, connect particular Kotpad pieces to particular designers or disclose product-level quantities and payments. Those missing details prevent a household outcome from being read directly from the event announcement.

Regional uses and new markets

The evidence does not require a choice between regional use and new garments as the single legitimate future of Kotpad textiles. They can coexist, change or matter differently to different households. Their relative importance remains unresolved, and publicity is not a measure of market share.

Yarn, cloth, design knowledge, credits and payments move through different relationships. Following them connects the receiving audience with the people who made the textile possible. Before any of these journeys can begin, households must obtain materials and fit production into the working year.

PART THREE · CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

CHAPTER 7

Water, roots, fuel and the working year

A dyeing process can be described as a sequence, but a household has to fit that sequence into a working year. Water must be accessible when yarn needs washing. Root material and fuel must be obtained before they are used. Drying requires suitable conditions, and a delay at one stage can affect the work that follows. Knowing how to produce a colour and being able to complete a batch are therefore connected but different things.

The accounts examined here identify several conditions affecting Kotpad textile work. They describe seasonal changes, contested access to shared water and material purchases. Their locations and dates differ. Read together, they show why the resources surrounding a loom deserve attention alongside the skill exercised at it.

Water that can actually be used

Annapurna Devi Pandey's pandemic-era account reports restrictions on washing treated yarn in ponds used for fish cultivation. It describes objections to yarn washing and a change in access to water previously used by weavers. The passage does not identify a particular pond, its management agreement or the dates of individual restrictions. It is an attributed access account, not evidence of a general current ban across Kotpad. [29]

Water may be present but unavailable for yarn washing. Access depends on who manages a site, its other uses and its suitability for the task. A dispute over use differs from a shortage of water.

A change of washing place may involve more carrying, transport or waiting. Pandey's account does not measure those possible costs, but it directs attention to access as part of the workplace.

Nor does a complaint about washing establish its environmental effect. The use of natural ingredients does not demonstrate harmless discharge, and an objection from another user does not by itself measure damage. Water quality and access arrangements require different evidence.

A working calendar with several activities

Dastkari Haat Samiti's weaving documentation, with images labelled 2017, describes a six-to-eight-week monsoon pause in coordinated dyeing and weaving work. Its separate dyeing account gives November to March as the dyeing period. One statement describes an interruption; the other identifies a seasonal window. They should not be forced into a single timetable. [30]; [20]

Gaatha records a different account attributed to weaver Raju Mohonto: about eight months of dyeing, with June to September avoided because drying is difficult. Differences in household practice, year or the stage being described could explain part of the variation. The accounts do not resolve which explanation applies. [31]

These accounts suggest a calendar with separate entries for dyeing, weaving, delivery and payment. Weaving may use yarn prepared earlier, and completion may precede payment. No single seasonal window can describe all these activities.

The room and the open space

Dastkari's documentation places much pre-weaving activity in courtyards and other open spaces, while describing weaving at pit looms within homes. This connects the working year to the organisation of space. The household workplace includes areas exposed to weather as well as the space occupied by the loom. [30]

The implication is that “a loom is available” and “the household can complete production” are not equivalent statements. Equipment is one part of a working arrangement. Space for preparation, drying and storage can matter too.

Roots obtained through relationships

The root material used in dyeing reaches practitioners through supply relationships. Uzramma’s account describes secondary-root bark moving from forest harvesters through traders to dyers, drawing on Jagada Rajappa’s field notes. It provides historical evidence of those connections, with the precise date of the Kotpad observation unresolved. [13]

A market purchase does not identify where the tree grew or how far the dyer travelled. Harvest location, trading route and purchase point are separate parts of a supply history.

For the same reason, sourcing distances reported by different authors cannot establish a trend without matching the routes, dates and material involved. An apparent increase might describe a different collector, purchase point or area of origin. The evidence reviewed here does not establish a measured rate of root depletion or a current supply volume.

As Chapter 4 explains, whole roots, bark and powder are different inputs. A procurement difficulty may concern quality or timing as much as availability and price.

Planting and dependable supply

A Caleidoscope article by Punyaprava Pradhan, displaying an update date of 18 August 2025, reports government planting of aal at Thenguda in Kotpad block in 2019. This supplies a named site and a reported planting year. It does not provide a survival count, harvest record or evidence of deliveries to dyers. [32]

A dependable supply would require surviving plants, access to harvest them and usable material reaching dyers. The planting

report follows none of those later stages, so it establishes neither a supply solution nor a failed plantation.

Fuel and the cost of a batch

Chitrangada Choudhury's 2017 reporting describes women tending dye vats heated with firewood. Pandey's account separately reports a shift from collecting wood to buying it, attributing the change to forest-department restrictions. The latter passage supplies no applicable order or dated series of purchases. It remains a reported change in sourcing, not a verified legal rule or a quantified cost trend. [16]; [29]

Fuel belongs within the cost of production, but a process duration does not provide its quantity. A batch extending over several weeks is not heated continuously for that period. Measuring fuel use would require the actual heating cycles and quantities, with household cooking and other uses distinguished where relevant.

The same care applies to claims of environmental advantage. Material reuse may be worth documenting, but it does not by itself establish the footprint of the whole process. No measured comparison of water, fuel and emissions is offered here.

Keeping work possible

Water, roots, fuel and weather enter the household economy through time as well as money. They can affect when work begins, what can proceed and when a promised product can be completed. This is the practical connection between resources and livelihoods; it need not be expressed as a single universal crisis to matter.

Kotpad's colours depend on knowledge exercised under material conditions. Supporting continued practice therefore involves more than admiration for the finished cloth. It requires attention to whether the people making it can obtain what they need, use the spaces on which they depend and organise their work through the year.

CHAPTER 8

What support programmes can show

A training event has a date, a place and people who attend. A lasting improvement in livelihoods has a longer history: what participants learned, whether they could use it, what work followed and what they received for that work. Programme records can illuminate parts of this history. Reading them well means recognising the achievement they document without asking a single attendance figure to describe everything that happened afterwards.

Kotpad appears in records of skills development, business training, design work and market promotion. These activities respond to different needs. Learning a technique, managing an enterprise and finding a buyer are related tasks, but they are not interchangeable. Their effects should be examined in relation to what each intervention actually tried to change.

An event that can be located

The Central University of Odisha's release of 19 October 2025 records management training organised with IIM Sambalpur at Sunabeda on 18-19 October. It reports 21 master weavers, including five women, from villages in Kotpad block. Branding, business management and digital platforms feature in the account. [24]

The release documents business development for people described as master weavers. It should not be counted as introductory loom training for 21 new practitioners.

The release announces another session for 25-26 October. An announcement records an intention; the same document cannot establish subsequent attendance at that session. Likewise,

discussion of an online platform is not a record of completed seller registration or sales. [24]

Targets and completed training

Koraput Farmers' Association's 2019-20 annual report describes National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (NABARD)-supported work with the Mirigan community and training in three villages. Its objectives refer to both 120 and 150 participants and a 40 per cent production increase. These figures do not form a reconciled count of unique people completing training and continuing production. [17]

KFA's report combines activity with objectives. Its participant figures cannot be added to other programme totals without checking for overlap and distinguishing individuals, households and group members.

Local change within a wider project

Asian Heritage Foundation's project P145419 was designed to support artisanal livelihoods across several states. An earlier restructuring record reports that women beneficiaries in Kotpad had taken up weaving. This is a specific claim about local participation. It does not establish a count of sustained practitioners or imply that no woman in Kotpad had woven before the intervention. [23]

Whether participants went on to accept paid orders, continued independently or added weaving to other responsibilities remains unresolved. Initial practice does not answer those questions or establish who received the proceeds.

Reading the results carefully

The World Bank's completion report, dated 26 July 2021, records an actual project closing date of 9 October 2019. It reports baseline and endline assessments and gives monitoring and evaluation a "Modest" rating. In the extracted results annex, reported income and sales-turnover increases are 83 and 76 per cent; narrative passages instead give 25 and 50 per cent. The difference remains unresolved. All are project-wide figures, not estimates of change in Kotpad. [33]

A 2019 restructuring paper adds a chronology issue. It reports 25.04 per cent income growth and 47.89 per cent more employment days from an independent sample survey while also stating that the endline consultant had commenced work. Those earlier figures cannot confidently be described as findings from an already completed endline. [34]

Different timing could explain some variation, but reconciling the figures requires comparable definitions, samples and observation periods, as well as the underlying evaluation. No one percentage can be adopted as definitive from this record.

The documents also belong to one reporting chain. Repetition across a restructuring paper, completion report and subsequent summary is not equivalent to independent replication. Their institutional provenance matters, but it does not remove the need to understand how each measure was produced.

From access to benefit

The same reasoning applies beyond training. A funded facility, a proposed improvement or a market showcase can be valuable without yet demonstrating sustained household gains. Each has its own sequence of evidence.

Infrastructure has to progress from approval to completion, use and performance. A sales intervention has to lead from contact to order, delivery and payment. Training needs opportunities to

practise. These are the stages at which records could connect programme activity to household benefit.

A programme can also benefit one aspect of work without changing another. Better design skills may coexist with uncertain orders. More orders may coexist with delayed settlement. Improved recognition may coexist with unresolved control over earnings. Evaluation becomes more informative when it identifies which change occurred rather than gathering every desirable result under one label of success.

Comparing experiences fairly

An increase following participation may also reflect changes in buyers, household circumstances or other support. Participants may already differ from nonparticipants. Assessing a programme's contribution therefore requires more than a before-and-after comparison.

The available material does not support that full comparison for Kotpad. This limits the conclusions; it does not establish that benefits were absent. Missing follow-up records and negative outcomes are different things.

Giving programmes an accurate place in the story

The records establish activities and reported changes, while leaving their lasting local effects uncertain. Keeping that distinction allows an intervention to be examined on its own terms. One important question remains for the people who participate: what opportunities follow for learning and continued practice?

CHAPTER 9

Learning and the future of weaving

In the People's Archive of Rural India (PARI) text accompanying Kavita Carneiro's film *A Weave in Time*, Madhusudhan Tanti describes weaving across generations of his family, including his son. He also does other work to support the household. The film was made in 2014; the account belongs to that documented family history rather than a description of conditions today. It nevertheless offers a useful starting point: continuing a skill and combining livelihoods can happen together. [35]

The future of Kotpad weaving cannot be understood only by asking whether younger people stay or leave. Learning, practising occasionally, accepting paid orders and relying on craft as a principal livelihood are different forms of participation. A person may move between them. The evidence available for this book does not measure how often that happens, but it makes the distinctions worth retaining.

Learning beyond the first lesson

Jagabandhu Panika's progression from simpler borders to more complex motifs, described in Chapter 5, makes learning visible as a continuing relationship with practice. [2]

Working alongside an experienced practitioner offers opportunities to watch, try, receive correction and judge a result. A written or filmed record can support this process, but it cannot reproduce the whole relationship through which learning takes place.

Choices about continuing

Published practitioners' accounts include worry about the next generation. In Diana Sahu's April 2020 report, Jemma speaks of the difficulty of attracting younger people to labour-intensive, time-consuming work, while she and Gobardhan Panika describe their wish to keep the craft alive. Their concern belongs in the history of the household and its work. It should not become a survey finding about every young person in the region. [21]

The Marangoni project account records interviews and group discussions with local youth during its 2023 fieldwork. It provides no representative measure of young people's intentions. Its account of artisan priorities emphasises documentation and access to new markets. Concern about continuity and efforts to create opportunities can therefore appear in the same record. [36]

A person can value a skill while doubting whether it will meet household needs. Another may have an opportunity to practise but prefer a different occupation. Education, health, care responsibilities and personal aspirations are possible parts of such decisions. They should be heard in participants' own terms rather than inferred from a general story about tradition.

Making room for practice

An opportunity to learn is more useful when there is a realistic way to use what has been learned. Materials, equipment, space, experienced guidance and orders can all enter that relationship. Their importance will vary with the task and the learner.

The earlier chapters showed why a household's ability to continue cannot be reduced to the presence of a loom. Dyeing has its own skill and resource requirements. Work may depend on people outside the home, while the timing of payment affects when receipts become available. These are connected conditions of practice, not evidence that one intervention will suit every household.

Recording knowledge and keeping it usable

The Marangoni-Creative Bee project account describes a collaboration during 2023-24 involving Kotpad dyers and weavers, documentation, design development and initial business-related training. It identifies recording processes and supporting market access as priorities reported by the artisans and Creative Bee. The account also describes designs developed within parameters set by the artisans. [36]

Documentation can retain names, processes and decisions that might otherwise be poorly recorded. It can also make knowledge accessible to people outside the immediate working relationship. Its value depends in part on what is recorded and how the practitioners' contributions are represented.

A film or illustrated book is not, however, evidence that a new practitioner has acquired the skill. Nor does a design collaboration by itself establish a continuing livelihood. Those outcomes require different records. Documentation and paid practice can support one another without being treated as interchangeable forms of preservation.

The reported use of artisan-defined parameters gives practitioners a role in deciding what is workable and desirable. It directs attention to who shapes a collaboration, while leaving its longer-term effects to be established.

Continuity without an obligation to remain unchanged

A craft's continuity need not require every product, working arrangement or market to remain fixed. The previous chapters described regional uses alongside newer garments and public showcases. Such changes can be examined in terms of what they enable and what they ask of the people doing the work.

The relevant question is not simply whether something new has appeared. It is how the change affects knowledge, workload, choice and returns. A new product may provide an opportunity, demand

extra learning or alter the risks of an order. The balance cannot be decided from its appearance alone.

Continuity also should not become an obligation imposed on younger people for the benefit of admirers elsewhere. Valuing textile knowledge is compatible with recognising that its practitioners and learners have aspirations beyond preserving it. A household-centred account asks what makes participation worthwhile and possible, rather than assuming participation must be its only acceptable choice.

Several futures within one tradition

PARI's family account returns the discussion to the coexistence of weaving and other employment. Several generations of practice appear alongside the need for more than one kind of work. For this family, combining livelihoods did not mean that knowledge had ceased to pass between generations. [35]

Learning, extending a skill, practising intermittently and choosing to stop are all possible trajectories. The available accounts cannot establish their proportions. A future described only through the most visible makers would miss that range of choices.

Roles within households can change too, as the records of women's participation in weaving and business training suggest. Continuity may involve new practitioners, different products or altered arrangements for work. What matters is whether people can use their knowledge on terms they find worthwhile.

Conclusion

A finished textile can bring colour, structure and design into a single field of attention. Following it back towards its making separates what that finished surface holds together: material preparation, skilled judgement, weaving, commissioning, exchange and payment. Following it forward reveals other relationships, with wearers, collectors, designers and institutions. Kotpad cloth belongs within these movements as well as within a named locality.

Following the work changes what a finished textile asks us to notice. A price contains costs and shared effort; a household contains several contributors; a collection label preserves only part of an object's history. These distinctions help connect appreciation of the cloth with the circumstances of its making.

Colour is central to that account. The sources describe preparation, repeated handling and judgements about readiness and shade. They also identify practitioners whose work deserves recognition in its own right. Understanding the dyer's contribution changes the idea of authorship: the person most visible at the loom or in the market may be one among several people whose decisions shaped the textile.

Knowledge becomes usable through material conditions: a place to wash yarn, suitable space for drying, supplies that arrive when needed and time to complete successive stages. These conditions connect the working year to the terms of an order. A delayed input or an inaccessible washing place can matter alongside the price eventually paid.

Support programmes enter this same working life. Training, documentation and market introductions address different needs. Their significance becomes clearer when records show what people could do afterwards: practise a skill, complete an order, receive payment or overcome a recurring interruption. The documents

examined here do not yet trace those outcomes consistently for Kotpad.

Learning brings these concerns together. Skills develop through practice, and practice takes time, materials and relationships. A younger person's interest in textile work cannot be understood apart from the circumstances in which that work would be done. Nor should the future be reduced to a choice between an unchanged tradition and its disappearance. The family account associated with A Weave in Time shows why other work and inherited knowledge can remain part of the same life.

The extent of current practice and the distribution of earnings remain open questions. This edition provides a basis for pursuing them without turning a named household or a programme total into a portrait of the whole region.

Kotpad's future will take shape through decisions about work, learning, resources and exchange. Careful description can recognise the knowledge involved and make its conditions more visible. The choices about what to continue, adapt or leave behind belong to the people doing the work.

Glossary

Aal The craft name used here for the root-derived dye material. It does not, by itself, verify the botanical identity of a supplier's plant.

Accession A collection's registration of an object. An accession reference does not by itself establish the object's manufacture date.

Commission An arrangement to make cloth to an order. The person commissioning and the people making may be different.

Elapsed time The period between stages or between beginning and completion, including waiting and drying; distinct from hands-on labour time.

Endline An assessment at or near a programme's end, to be read with its sample, indicators and observation period.

Gram panchayat A unit of local government. Its boundary is not automatically the boundary of a craft locality or production network.

Hank Yarn arranged in loops for handling and processing.

Mai luga Cloth described in Dhingra's regional account as a wedding gift from the groom to the bride's mother; not a universal designation assigned to all Kotpad cloth.

Mirgan and spelling variants Names retained in this book and its sources, including Mirigan and Mirigáni. Shared spelling or occupation alone does not establish identity.

Pit loom A loom arrangement with a recessed space for the weaver's legs, documented in the process accounts.

Provenance The documented history linking an object to its making, ownership and movement.

Settlement In the transaction chapters, payment of an amount owed. Elsewhere the word can mean an inhabited locality.

A chronology of the records

This chronology dates selected records and reported events discussed in the chapters. It is not a continuous history of the craft.

1907 and 1909 Francis and Thurston publish records using community names discussed in Chapter 2. These are documentary anchors, not founding dates.

Late 1996 Chishti's account dates Kalingavastra collection production with Sambalpur Bastralaya to this period; it does not independently date entry 10/42.

2014 Kavita Carneiro's A Weave in Time is made. The accompanying family account is read in Chapter 9 as historical testimony.

2017 Choudhury's dyer reporting is published; Dastkari process images carry this year. These are separate source dates.

2019 Thenguda planting is later reported as occurring this year. P145419 closes on 9 October. Neither event establishes a Kotpad livelihood outcome.

2021 The World Bank completion report is dated 26 July, after the project's closure.

2023-24 The Marangoni-Creative Bee collaboration takes place according to its institutional account.

2025 The Central University of Odisha reports management training on 18-19 October; Boito appears in India Art Fair's 2025 archive. These are different activities.

2026 The Ministry records the New Delhi showcase on 7 August. This reading edition is assembled on 10 November without a field visit.

Source notes

Geography and names

Sambad's regional exchange account was reviewed through indexed Odia text. Census village codes retain their 2011 reference year. Batasana is a candidate administrative match, not a confirmed household address. The Samarth address is an indexed lead. No current boundary map or population estimate is asserted.

Historical records and objects

Francis and Thurston preserve historical classifications, not contemporary self-identification. MAP details retain the earlier catalogue review's status. The book does not infer a workshop from a regional attribution. Uzramma's filename date and the span of Rajappa's field notes do not establish the date of the Kotpad observations. Chishti's page references apply to the older scan consulted, not a later edition.

Transactions and contributors

Pandey's reported sale is a household example, not an audited cost record. KFA's price and cost ranges are not paired transactions. The YourStory interview and Boito maker page share Jagabandhu as a subject; the latter is hosted by a commercial partner. Neither provides a representative measure of net earnings or household control of money.

Process and resources

The process chapter is descriptive, not a tested recipe. Dhingra, Dastkari and Sahu describe variations that have not been combined into a universal sequence. Botanical names are source identifications. Met newsletter text and captions were consulted without new examination of the objects or practices. No ecological assessment, fuel measurement, colourfastness test or water-quality test was undertaken.

Markets and programmes

Exhibition and event records establish visibility, not item-level sales. The 2018 project passage on women's weaving retains its earlier indexed status. World Bank results were inspected as extracted document text; annex and narrative percentages remain unreconciled, and the original evaluation data and Kotpad-specific outcome breakdown were unavailable. CUO's announced second session is not counted as completed.

Learning and the proceedings discrepancy

PARI's alternate site supplied the text accompanying a 2014 film; footage and a transcript were not reviewed. The Marangoni institutional project page supports the collaboration account. The linked proceedings repository was inaccessible, and two indexed records carried different identifiers for the Scott-Murden paper. That paper and its previously indexed youth-interest finding are excluded. No representative youth survey is claimed.

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The work behind the cloth

Behind a finished textile are people whose work may be only partly visible: dyers preparing colour, weavers shaping cloth, teachers passing on skills and households arranging materials and orders.

Mirgan Households and Kotpad Textiles follows these relationships across Odisha. Its nine chapters explore the judgement involved in making colour, the people sharing the proceeds of a sari, the journeys cloth takes and the demands of the working year. They also consider what support programmes can show and how skills pass between generations.

Prepared from published sources without a field visit, this first edition brings named testimony together with historical records and documented practice. It invites readers to look closely at the knowledge, choices and livelihoods behind the cloth, with references for further reading.

